up exercises.

It was amazing the way everyone agreed with me and the way in which everyone said nothing could be done. On November 19, I was officially switched into a basic-training unit, and on the next day I began the process.

There were two hours of drill, followed by two films, one on military courtesy, which I had seen before, and another warning soldiers against venereal disease. In the evening I was given a rifle—a real, honest-to-God, working rifle—and it was the first time I ever held a firearm of any kind. We had calisthenics, too.

On Thanksgiving (November 22) I had all the turkey, and everything else, I could eat, so for that one day I was fairly consoled. And in the library I found a copy of the December 1945 Astounding, with the second part of "The Mule," which I read with somber pleasure. It reminded me of those already distant-seeming civilian days when I was writing it. It made me remember the days when I was an individual and of some importance.

4

On November 23, I had another interesting KP session. I was given the role of stevedore this time. I drove in a truck with another soldier who was, fortunately for me, an eighteen-year-old farmboy with a kindly nature and muscles of iron. We loaded and unloaded sacks of potatoes, bags of flour, crates of oranges, chicken, meat, fish, and so on. We weren't exactly stevedores, at that. A stevedore would have worked eight hours; we worked thirteen. My partner did far more than his share of the work.

Finally, we were shown huge stacks of aluminum serving trays on which soldiers ate their meals and were told to shift them from one end of a mess hall to another. These serving trays fit together snugly so that to lift a stack that is a foot high is the equivalent of lifting a hundred pounds or more of solid aluminum.

I couldn't even begin to lift such a weight so I lifted stacks that were about two to three inches high and my partner (smaller and slighter than I) lifted considerably higher stacks.

The soldier in charge (only a private first class, heaven help us) watched in gathering annoyance and said to me, "Hey soldier, what's the idea of letting your partner do all the work?"